



Ages 11 to 14

Online Bullying: What to Do

What online bullying is, what to do if it happens to you or a friend, and where to get help. For all students.

Before You Read This guide talks about online bullying, threats and messages about self-harm.

This guide is about online bullying, including threats and messages that tell someone to hurt themselves. Some of it might feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Being online should be fun and a way to stay close to friends. This guide explains what to do if someone uses messages, posts, games or group chats to **hurt, scare or embarrass** you or someone else.

- It can come from someone you know, a group, or an account with no name.
- It can happen to **anyone**, whoever they are.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, and you don't have to sort it out on your own.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.

- If a message tells you to hurt yourself, or you feel like hurting yourself, **tell an adult now**. You can also call Childline any time.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Online bullying

When someone keeps using phones, apps, games or the internet to hurt, scare or leave out another person on purpose.

Threat

A message saying someone will hurt you or do something bad to you. Always tell an adult about a threat.

Anonymous account

An account that hides who is really behind it. It might be someone you know.

Bystander

Someone who sees what is happening. Bystanders can help by telling an adult.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a teacher, tutor, coach, house parent, counsellor or family member.

Joke, Fall-Out or Bullying?

A Joke or a Fall-Out

- Everyone is laughing, including the person it's about
- It stops when someone says they don't like it
- Friends sort it out and say sorry

Bullying or Abuse

- It's aimed at one person, and they're not laughing
- It keeps happening, or lots of people join in
- It makes someone scared, sad or left out

- It picks on who someone is, like their skin colour, religion, disability or who they like

Bullying is often something that keeps happening. **But you don't have to wait for it to happen again before you tell an adult.** A threat, or a message telling you to hurt yourself, is serious the very first time.

What It Can Look Like

- Nasty messages, comments or voice notes
- Threats to hurt you, or to "get" you somewhere
- Messages telling you to hurt yourself
- Embarrassing photos or edited pictures shared in a group chat
- Fake accounts pretending to be you
- Being left out of group chats on purpose, or others being told to ignore you
- Mean polls, memes or comments about you

If It Happens to You

What to Do

- **Don't reply, and don't get back at them.** That's what they want, and it can make things worse.
- **Keep it.** Don't delete the messages. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help keep the messages safely.
- **Tell a trusted adult.** If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- Most apps also let you report a message or account. An adult can help you do it.
- **Look after yourself.** It's OK to turn off notifications or take a break from an app. Spend time with people who are kind to you.

You Don't Have to Be a Detective

- You don't have to work out who is sending the messages, collect proof, or keep checking what people are saying about you.

- Don't make a fake account to find out who it is or to get back at them.
- Sorting it out is the adults' job.

If a Message Tells You to Hurt Yourself

Tell Someone Now

- **Tell a trusted adult straight away.** You will not be in trouble.
- The words are meant to hurt you. They are not true, and they are not your fault.
- If you feel like hurting yourself, tell an adult now, or call **Childline** on 0800 1111, any time.
- If you are in danger or have hurt yourself, call 999.

If a friend shows you a message like this, or tells you they want to hurt themselves, **tell an adult straight away**, even if they ask you not to.

RESPOND: If It's Happening to Someone Else

Most people see online bullying happen to someone else. What bystanders do makes a big difference. Here is what you can do.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Is someone being picked on in a group chat, or sent nasty messages?
- Has a friend gone quiet, or seem scared of their phone?
- You don't need to be sure to do something



Engage

Talk and listen.

- Message or talk to your friend privately: "I saw what happened. Are you OK?"
- **If it is safe to do so**, the best ways to help are to **tell an adult**, **change the subject** or invite your friend to do something else, and **check in with them later**
- Don't pile in, argue with the person doing it, or reply with something nasty



Support

Be there.

- "It's not your fault. I'm on your side."
- Keep including them, online and offline

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Stop and think.

- **Don't share, like, forward or comment on the post**, even to stick up for someone. It spreads it further
- Don't try to find out who is behind an account, or collect evidence
- Don't promise to keep it a secret if someone could get hurt

Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Show them there's help.

- Tell your friend a trusted adult can help, and offer to go with them
- Report the post or account on the app, if you can do it safely



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell an adult what you saw. **If there's a threat, or a message about self-harm, tell them straight away**
- That isn't snitching. It's how people get help



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what you saw



Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- They won't go and have a go at anyone. They'll make a plan with the school's safeguarding team to keep you safe.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

Whoever You Are

- No one should be picked on because of their skin colour, religion, disability, how they look or sound, or who they are. That kind of bullying is taken very seriously.

- If you're LGBTQ+ and someone is threatening to tell people about you, you can talk to a trusted adult. Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- If you find it hard to tell whether something is a joke or not, that's fine: ask an adult you trust.

If You've Been Part of It

Sometimes people join in because everyone else is, or because they're scared of being next. If you've sent, shared or laughed at something that hurt someone, you can stop now.

- Stop sending or sharing it, and don't delete things if an adult asks you to keep them.
- Talk to an adult you trust. It's better to own up than to wait.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's only online, so it's not real"	Online bullying hurts just as much, and it can follow you home.
"Just ignore it and it'll stop"	Sometimes it doesn't. Telling an adult is the best way to make it stop.
"Telling is snitching"	Telling is how people get help. Threats and self-harm messages always need an adult.
"If I don't know who it is, nothing can be done"	Adults can still help and keep you safe, even if nobody knows who it is yet.
"Sharing it to show people is OK"	Sharing spreads the hurt. Tell an adult instead.

If You Board

- You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.
- If messages arrive at night, tell a house parent, even late in the evening. You don't have to wait until morning.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout**: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Online Bullying: What to Do: Student Guide 3 - 11 to 14

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